

## APA Patch Program – Comprehensive Guide

APA (American Poolplayers Association) leagues offer various **embroidered patches** to recognize player achievements in 8-Ball and 9-Ball formats. Below we detail **all the patches currently available**, which patches are actually awarded in the **Rio Grande Valley (RGV) APA** under League Operator Erin Lacy, and how to obtain patches *not* handed out locally. We've also included images and descriptions of each patch for clarity.

### APA 8-Ball Achievement Patches

APA's 8-Ball format has several performance-based patches for specific feats during a match:

- **8-on-the-Break (8OB):** Earned by legally sinking the 8-ball on the break without fouling <sup>1</sup>. (This instant win is a thrilling feat; patch designs often show an 8-ball exploding out of a rack.) For example, *the APA "8 On The Break" patch is awarded for pocketing the 8 on a legal break* <sup>2</sup>.
- **8-Ball Break and Run (8BR):** Earned by making at least one ball on the break *and* then running the table, pocketing all your balls plus the 8 without giving up a turn <sup>3</sup>. This is essentially a perfect game from the break in 8-ball.
- **8-Ball Mini-Slam:** Awarded for accomplishing **both** an 8-on-the-break **and** an 8-break-and-run in the **same night** (single match or league night) <sup>4</sup>. Some leagues issue a dedicated "8-Ball Mini Slam" patch instead of two separate patches <sup>5</sup>. (If separate patches are given, a player might receive both an 8OB and 8BR patch; some LOs, however, opt to give one combined Mini-Slam patch to limit the number of patches.)
- **Rackless Night:** Awarded in 8-ball when your opponent **never gets to break** during the match <sup>6</sup>. In APA's alternating-break format, a "rackless" match means you won the lag and then won every rack you broke, so the other player never broke. (This indicates a dominant performance.) The patch often features a broken rack or "no rack" symbol. *Per APA rules, a Rackless patch is earned by "starting out breaking in a match and continuing to win (thus you keep the break) until the match is won," so your opponent doesn't rack at all* <sup>6</sup>. **Note:** Some areas restrict Rackless patches to lower-skilled players or require the opponent to be of equal/higher skill <sup>7</sup>, but generally in RGV APA any player can earn it with the proper scenario.

*Example APA patch for an "8 on the Break," awarded when a player sinks the 8-ball on the break in 8-Ball* <sup>1</sup>. Many APA 8OB patches feature an 8-ball graphic and bold text celebrating the achievement.

- **"I Beat a 6" / "I Beat a 7":** These are *upset* patches in 8-ball, awarded when a lower-skilled player defeats a high skill level. In APA 8-ball, skill levels range 2–7, so beating a Skill Level 6 or 7 as an underdog is notable. For instance, *an "I Beat a 7" patch is earned by winning against an opponent ranked SL7 in 8-ball* <sup>8</sup> (usually the winner must be at least 2 levels lower – e.g. SL5 or below – as

many LOs require a significant skill gap for these upsets). **RGV APA:** Historically, RGV APA did **not** routinely award the “I Beat a \_\_\_” patches (Erin Lacy focused on performance patches), so players in RGV might not have seen these. They do exist in the APA inventory <sup>9</sup>, but Erin may choose not to hand them out due to cost or philosophy. (Players who really want an “I Beat a 7” patch can still obtain one – see **Obtaining Unawarded Patches** below.)

- **“I Beat the League Operator”:** A special patch for any player who manages to defeat the League Operator in a regular handicapped match <sup>10</sup>. This is tongue-in-cheek and quite rare (many LOs don’t play in weekly league, and if they do, they’re often high skill). *APA describes it as “Feeling lucky? Earned when playing and winning against the League Operator... Difficult to win due to the time restraints and impressive skills of most LOs”* <sup>10</sup>. **RGV APA:** Erin Lacy typically does **not** play in the weekly rotations (being busy running league), so this patch isn’t commonly earned or awarded in RGV. It exists nationally, but RGV players won’t encounter it unless Erin actively participates as a player.
- **“I Won My First Match!”:** A patch to celebrate a brand-new APA member’s **first ever match win** <sup>11</sup>. This is a one-time patch for newcomers, intended to welcome them. **RGV APA:** These *are* awarded – new RGV players can request an “I Won My First Match” patch after that initial victory. If you didn’t automatically get it, just note it on the scoresheet or let Erin know and she’ll provide it (often, such patches are available upon request if not handed out immediately).

## APA 9-Ball Achievement Patches

The 9-Ball format has its own set of patches, parallel to 8-ball in many ways:

- **9-on-the-Snap (9OS or 9OB):** Earned by pocketing the 9-ball on a legal break without fouling <sup>12</sup>. This is the 9-ball equivalent of the 8-on-the-break. (Many patches actually say “9 on the Snap.”) *Any player who breaks and sinks the 9 earns this patch* <sup>12</sup>.
- **9-Ball Break and Run (9BR):** Earned by legally making at least one ball on the break *and* running all remaining balls in the rack, ending by sinking the 9, without giving up the turn <sup>13</sup>. This is a perfect game in 9-ball. *All skill levels are eligible for 9B&R patches* <sup>14</sup>.

*Example APA patch for a “9-Ball Break & Run.” This patch is earned by breaking and running the entire rack in 9-ball* <sup>13</sup>. *The design usually features the 9-ball; completing a 9B&R is a mark of excellent play.*

- **9-Ball Mini-Slam:** Awarded for scoring a 9-on-the-snap **and** a 9-break-and-run in the **same night** <sup>15</sup>. Like the 8-ball mini-slam, some LOs (including RGV APA) issue a single “9-Ball Mini Slam” patch when both feats occur on the same league night, instead of two separate patches. (If RGV APA players mark both achievements, Erin will likely issue the Mini-Slam patch to cover both, rather than two patches, as a policy to manage patch inventory.)
- **20-0 Shutout:** Earned by winning a 9-ball match with a perfect score of **20-0** <sup>16</sup>. In APA 9-ball, a player races to a certain point total (14, 19, or 21 points depending on skill level). A “20-0” means you held your opponent to zero points while reaching 20 or more yourself – a dominant shutout. Often called the “Skunk” patch (and some older designs even feature a skunk), it signifies a blowout victory <sup>17</sup>. *Any 9-ball player who wins 20-0 against an established opponent earns this patch* <sup>7</sup>. **RGV APA:**

Yes, RGV awards the 20-0 patch. If you score a shutout, be sure it's noted on the scoresheet to get your patch.

- **“I Beat a 7/8/9” (9-Ball Upset patches):** In 9-ball, high skill levels go up to SL9 for males (SL7 is highest for females in some areas). APA offers upset patches for beating skill level 7, 8, or 9 in 9-ball <sup>18</sup>. Typically, these are for lower-skilled players (SL5 or below) who defeat an SL7/8/9 in a regular match. For example, *the “I Beat a 9” patch is earned by beating a SL9 in 9-ball during regular league play or higher-level tournaments* <sup>19</sup>. **RGV APA:** Historically, Erin’s league has **not** been handing out these “I beat \_\_\_” upset patches for 9-ball, similar to 8-ball. The majority of patches distributed in RGV are performance-based, not opponent-based. So, while the patches exist (and some players *want* them), you would not automatically get an “I beat a 9” patch in RGV APA unless policies change or you request/buy one yourself <sup>20</sup> <sup>21</sup>.

## Team & Session Patches (All Formats)

Some patches recognize team achievements or multi-format accomplishments:

- **Clean Sweep (5-0) Patch:** Awarded when your team wins **all 5 matches** in a league night (applies to both 8-ball and 9-ball team matches) <sup>22</sup>. Every player who played in those wins gets a patch. (For 9-ball, although points decide the team win, APA still uses a “5-0” sweep patch if your team won all five individual matchups.) *Forfeits don’t count – you must actually win five played matches for a sweep* <sup>23</sup>. The patch often says “5-0” or “Clean Sweep” with a graphic (e.g. a broom). **RGV APA:** Yes, RGV does award Clean Sweep patches for both formats. Make sure to mark “5-0 sweep” on the scoresheet if your team blanks the opponents, and Erin will include the patch in your packet.

*An APA “Clean Sweep” patch (5-0 patch) for team shutouts* <sup>23</sup>. *This patch is given to each team member who played in a 5-0 victory. Designs often feature a broom or “5-0” text, indicating a complete sweep.*

- **Grand Slam Patch:** Highly coveted, this is earned by accomplishing **all four** major feats in one session: an 8-on-the-break, an 8-break-and-run, a 9-on-the-snap, **and** a 9-break-and-run <sup>24</sup>. Earning a Grand Slam means you’ve achieved both the 8-Ball and 9-Ball Mini Slams in one session – a sign of all-around excellence. *APA describes the Grand Slam patch as “a great accomplishment” awarded when a player gets at least one of each patch (8OB, 8BR, 9OB, 9BR) in the same session* <sup>24</sup>. **RGV APA:** Yes, if you manage this, Erin Lacy will recognize it! Grand Slam patches are typically **free** and given at session’s end once verified <sup>25</sup>. (You might not see it until the session is over, so ensure all your individual achievements were noted so the LO knows you qualified.) Not many achieve this, but RGV has awarded it to the rare players who do.
- **MVP or Top Gun Patches:** Many APA areas run MVP/Top Gun programs where the top player(s) in each division or tier each session get recognized. In some areas, the prize includes an MVP patch. For example, First Coast APA gives an MVP patch plus a prize to the highest finishing players in each tier <sup>26</sup>. **RGV APA:** RGV does hold MVP tournaments and honors top performers, but Erin typically awards trophies or invites to MVP events rather than a patch alone. Check with Erin if RGV has a specific MVP patch – as of now, RGV’s focus is on the tournaments (with trophies/prizes) more so than issuing a patch.

- **Higher-Level Tournament Patches:** APA National/Regional events (e.g., City/World Qualifiers) often have special patches for accomplishments during those tournaments. For instance, some areas give “HLT 8-on-Break” or “HLT Break&Run” patches if you do it in a Tri-Cup or World Qualifier (marked with “HLT”). Birmingham APA notes High Level Tournament patches separately <sup>27</sup>. **RGV APA:** When RGV players go to regionals or Vegas, they may receive special event patches from those events (for example, national singles champions get patches, etc.). Locally, RGV doesn’t have separate *designs* for HLT – they use the same patch designs, but the achievement is usually just noted verbally or via certificates.

## Milestone & Leadership Patches

APA also awards patches for longevity and leadership roles:

- **Matches Played (Milestone) Patches:** These commemorate the total number of lifetime matches you’ve played in APA (8-ball + 9-ball combined). APA produces patches for milestones like **100, 250, 500, 750, 1000** (and some areas even go beyond to 1500, 2000, etc.) <sup>28</sup> <sup>29</sup>. *For example, once you reach 100 matches, you can get the 100 Matches patch; higher milestones like 500 and 1000 have their own patches* <sup>28</sup>. **RGV APA:** Erin Lacy’s policy is that milestone patches are **available upon request**. They are not automatically given the week you hit the number, but if you or your captain lets her know (or marks the scoresheet), she will provide the patch. RGV definitely has 100, 250, 500, 750, 1000 in stock for those who qualify – and if you surpass 1000, coordinate with Erin for higher-level patches (APA does have 1500+ as needed). Always feel free to ask for your milestone patch if you hit the magic number and didn’t get it yet.
- **Team Captain / Co-Captain Patch:** APA appreciates team leaders by offering patches for serving as a captain or co-captain for a full session <sup>30</sup> <sup>31</sup>. These typically say “Team Captain” or “Team Co-Captain.” **RGV APA:** These leadership patches are *not automatically handed out* every session in RGV. However, Erin does have them available. In some cases, RGV gives captains a small gift at session’s end (like a pin or token) instead of a patch. If you specifically want the patch, you can request it – “*Team Captain*” and “*Co-Captain*” patches are *one per player per year upon request* in some areas <sup>32</sup>. So, RGV captains can certainly get one (especially if you haven’t before) by asking Erin or marking the patch request form.
- **Division Representative Patch:** Awarded if you serve as a Division Rep (a player-volunteer who helps the LO in a division) <sup>33</sup>. **RGV APA:** These are rare and given only to those appointed as reps. If RGV has division reps, Erin will provide this patch as appropriate.
- **Sportsmanship Award Patch:** APA encourages good sportsmanship by letting players nominate others for a Sportsmanship patch <sup>11</sup> <sup>34</sup>. If someone on another team exemplifies great attitude, you can write a nomination, and the league may award them a “Good Sportsmanship” patch. It usually shows a handshake or trophy icon. **RGV APA:** Erin Lacy does support sportsmanship awards. While not common every week, if you send a nomination (RGV has a form for Good Sportsmanship nominations), the league office will review it. Worthy recipients will indeed get a patch saying “Sportsmanship” as a special recognition <sup>11</sup>. So yes, RGV APA has this patch – but it’s only awarded when *you* nominate someone who truly earned it.

## Patches RGV APA Does and Does Not Award

To summarize for RGV (Erin Lacy's league):

- **Awarded in RGV:** All the standard *performance* patches are given: 8-on-Break, 8-Break&Run, 9-on-Snap, 9-Break&Run, Rackless, 20-0 Shutout, Clean Sweep (team 5-0), and Grand Slam (if earned) <sup>22</sup>  
<sup>16</sup> . RGV also honors **Mini-Slams** in both formats – but instead of two separate patches, you'll receive a single Mini-Slam patch per format (one for 8-ball night, one for 9-ball night) if you accomplish both feats in one night. First Match win patches are available for new players, and milestone patches (100+ matches) are given on request. Sportsmanship patches are awarded if nominations are made (not automatic). Team Captain/Co-Captain patches can be obtained (usually on request at end of session, since not automatically distributed). Essentially, **RGV APA provides patches for game feats and team feats, and will provide other patches if you ask or qualify**, even if they're not routinely handed out.
- **Not Typically Awarded in RGV:** The "I Beat a [Skill]" upset patches have **not** been part of RGV's regular patch program. As confirmed by player discussions, some LOs choose not to offer these (often due to cost or to discourage any unsportsmanlike gloating) <sup>20</sup> . Erin Lacy historically did not include "I Beat a 7/8/9" patches in weekly awards. Also, the "Beat the LO" patch is essentially moot in RGV due to Erin focusing on league management (she isn't playing weekly league matches against members). If Erin ever does play and you beat her, well, you could lobby for that patch – but in general it's not in circulation.

Additionally, patches like **MVP/Top Gun** are not given as patches in RGV – instead, MVPs get invitations to the MVP tournament and sometimes trophies or other prizes, but not a specific patch each session. Lastly, *High Level Tournament* specific patches (like ones labeled for City or Vegas events) are not distributed locally; any special event patches would come from the events themselves or not at all.

**In summary, RGV APA awards the common patches that most players earn during league play, but excludes a few of the rarer or "extra" patches unless requested.** This is similar to many APA areas – *for instance, one APA member noted their league operator only offers "the most common ones" and not things like the upset patches* <sup>35</sup> . Erin's approach has been to focus on core achievements (so everyone gets recognition for great shots and matches), while keeping the patch program manageable.

## Obtaining Patches Not Handed Out Locally

Just because RGV APA doesn't normally give a certain patch doesn't mean you can't get it. APA players often collect patches from various sources. Here are ways to obtain patches Erin Lacy might not automatically provide:

- **Request from the League Operator:** The first step is simply asking Erin. She has access to the APA patch inventory and can order any official patch. If you earn something like "I Beat a 7" and really want that patch for your collection, talk to her. Many LOs are willing to accommodate one-off requests (possibly for a small fee to cover costs). RGV APA uses Patch Request Forms – just write in the patch you want (with details of your achievement) and there's a good chance you can get it at the

end of the session. Remember, *"Patches are free" for earned achievements in APA* <sup>36</sup>, so if you earned it, you can ask for it even if it's not routine in your area.

- **APA Patch Store / Other League Operators:** Some APA areas sell patches directly to players online. For example, the Maryland APA has an **APA Patch Store** where players can purchase extra or less-common patches for ~\$1.50 each <sup>37</sup> <sup>38</sup>. This includes patches like "I Beat a 7/8/9" etc. The store is typically intended for their local players, but it's a public website <sup>39</sup>. You could try ordering through such sites (or a friendly LO) if needed. *The APA Patch Store lists essentially all patches (8-ball, 9-ball, and even Masters) for purchase* <sup>38</sup> <sup>40</sup>, so any patch APA makes is obtainable one way or another.
- **Trading with Players:** APA patches are often traded or given among players, especially at national events. If you know someone from another area or go to APA Vegas events, you can sometimes trade duplicates for ones you need. (Many veteran players have extras of common patches and might happily trade an "I Beat a 7" if they have one, etc.)
- **Online Marketplaces:** As a last resort, you can find APA patches on eBay and similar sites (sold by collectors). For example, eBay frequently has listings for specific patches (like "APA 5-0 Clean Sweep patch" <sup>41</sup> or sets of "I Beat \_\_\_\_" patches). **However, buying patches you didn't earn** is a bit like buying trophies – it's fine for completing a collection or replacing a lost patch, but wear them with integrity! It's always better to earn it or get it through your LO if possible.

In short, **any patch APA offers is out there and can be obtained**. RGV APA focuses on the core patches, but Erin Lacy won't begrudge you getting the others – she just doesn't automatically stock or distribute every single type. If you're a RGV player who achieved something notable that isn't usually awarded, communicate with the league office. And if that fails, the wider APA community and marketplace can fill the gap. *(One player in an APA discussion said: "My LO doesn't pass these out, but I want one," regarding an I Beat a 7 patch* <sup>20</sup> *– a common sentiment. The solutions were to ask the LO or find it online.)*

## Conclusion and Last 10 Years of Patch Evolution

Over the last decade, APA's patch program has expanded slightly (adding things like the **upset patches**, **Mini-Slams**, and even higher match count patches as more players hit milestones). But the core patches have remained the same. An APA member from 10+ years ago would recognize almost all the patches used today: 8-on-break, 9-on-snap, break-and-runs, shutouts, rackless, and clean sweeps were all around, and they still are <sup>42</sup> <sup>43</sup>. What's changed is some leagues now offer **more** patches (to reward a wider variety of feats), whereas others keep it basic. For example, years ago some areas didn't give "I Beat \_\_\_\_" patches at all, considering them optional – and that's still the case in RGV APA today. Conversely, new patches like "I Won My First Match" have been introduced to encourage beginners (this wasn't common a decade ago). And APA has added higher-tier milestone patches (1500+ matches) as players stay in league longer <sup>29</sup>.

Erin Lacy's RGV APA has largely stuck to the classic patches to reward great shots and matches. **To recap, if you're playing in RGV APA, you can earn the following patches through normal league play:**

- **8-Ball:** 8 on Break, 8 Break & Run, Rackless, 8-Ball Mini-Slam (or the two individual patches if policy changes), and *I Beat 6/7 (available on request, but not automatic)*.
- **9-Ball:** 9 on Snap, 9 Break & Run, 20-0 Shutout, 9-Ball Mini-Slam, and *I Beat 7/8/9 (on request only)*.

- *Either*: Clean Sweep (team 5-0), Grand Slam (session combo), First Match win, Sportsmanship (by nomination).
- *Other*: Milestones (100+ matches), Captain/Co-Captain, Division Rep (if applicable).

All patches above are part of APA's official offerings <sup>3</sup> <sup>22</sup> . RGV APA awards most of them proactively except a few upset/novelty ones – but those can still be acquired if you're keen. Between RGV's Facebook page and scoresheet notices, Erin often reminds players to **use the Patch Request Form** to ensure they get their patches. *For instance, a league post might say: "Most packets now have our patch request forms, please fill in the team name, names of players receiving patches and check the patches won"* – emphasizing that if you don't ask, you might not receive <sup>44</sup> .

Finally, if you're looking for **images** of each patch for reference or design (perhaps to display or scrapbook your achievements), here's advice: APA itself doesn't publish high-res images of patches publicly, but many league sites and player posts have photos. We've embedded a few examples above (8OB, 9BR, Clean Sweep). You can find others by searching online (e.g. "*APA patch collection*" on Pinterest or Facebook) – some collectors have posted pictures of every patch they've collected over decades <sup>45</sup> <sup>46</sup> . Additionally, the **APA Merchandise Store** occasionally sells patch display banners or patch sets, which include visuals.

Erin Lacy would surely be happy to see players enthusiastic about the patch program – it means you're taking pride in your game. So keep chasing those patches! Mark your scoresheets, communicate with the league office, and you can **earn and collect every patch APA has to offer**, whether through RGV APA directly or through the wider APA network. Good luck and good shooting!

#### Sources:

- APA Southern Tier NY – "*League Patches*" (patch types and criteria) <sup>3</sup> <sup>22</sup> <sup>47</sup>
- APA Maryland – "*APA Patch Store*" (lists of available patches for purchase) <sup>38</sup> <sup>40</sup> <sup>25</sup>
- APA Tampa Bay – Patch definitions (confirms common patch meanings) <sup>48</sup> <sup>49</sup>
- APA First Coast (FL) – Patch program update (adding new patches like Beat LO, First Win) <sup>7</sup> <sup>50</sup>
- AzBilliards Forum – Discussion by APA members/LOs on patches offered (shows variation by area and available patch types) <sup>43</sup> <sup>51</sup>
- APA South Charlotte – *Member Patches* page (notes upset patch availability in 8-ball and 9-ball) <sup>52</sup>

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<sup>1</sup> <sup>2</sup> <sup>3</sup> <sup>4</sup> <sup>6</sup> <sup>8</sup> <sup>9</sup> <sup>10</sup> <sup>11</sup> <sup>12</sup> <sup>13</sup> <sup>15</sup> <sup>16</sup> <sup>18</sup> <sup>22</sup> <sup>23</sup> <sup>24</sup> <sup>28</sup> <sup>30</sup> <sup>31</sup> <sup>33</sup> <sup>36</sup> <sup>47</sup> League Patches

<https://stny.apaleagues.com/CustomPage.aspx?q=4598>

<sup>5</sup> <sup>26</sup> <sup>29</sup> <sup>32</sup> <sup>34</sup> First Coast APA - Patches

<https://sites.google.com/view/322apa/home/patches>

<sup>7</sup> <sup>50</sup> APA Patch Program

<https://league.poolplayers.com/FirstCoast/post/27794>

<sup>14</sup> <sup>17</sup> <sup>19</sup> birmingham.apaleagues.com

[https://birmingham.apaleagues.com/Uploads/birmingham/apa\\_patches/\\_9-Ball\\_Patches-website.pdf](https://birmingham.apaleagues.com/Uploads/birmingham/apa_patches/_9-Ball_Patches-website.pdf)

<sup>20</sup> Where to buy apa patches for beating a 7? - Facebook

<https://www.facebook.com/groups/5338694612916147/posts/24782449238114061/>

21 Show us your Patches : r/billiards - Reddit

[https://www.reddit.com/r/billiards/comments/1jr2gak/show\\_us\\_your\\_patches/](https://www.reddit.com/r/billiards/comments/1jr2gak/show_us_your_patches/)

25 37 38 39 40 APA APA PATCH STORE

<https://league.poolplayers.com/Maryland/post/36490>

27 [PDF] HLT PATCHES - Birmingham APA

[https://birmingham.apaleagues.com/Uploads/birmingham/apa\\_patches/\\_HLT\\_Patches-website.pdf](https://birmingham.apaleagues.com/Uploads/birmingham/apa_patches/_HLT_Patches-website.pdf)

35 APA patches : r/billiards - Reddit

[https://www.reddit.com/r/billiards/comments/1dacy0l/apa\\_patches/](https://www.reddit.com/r/billiards/comments/1dacy0l/apa_patches/)

41 APA 5-0 Clean Sweep Patch American Poolplayers Association 8 ...

<https://www.ebay.com/itm/116447783829>

42 43 51 Your Local APA League | AzBilliards Forums

<https://forums.azbilliards.com/threads/your-local-apa-league.197272/>

44 NEW!!!! Check out the NEW Table Assignment post in the Pool ...

<https://www.facebook.com/groups/917001756321224/posts/1251700942851302/>

45 APA Pool League Patch Collections - Facebook

<https://www.facebook.com/groups/5338694612916147/posts/8891450727640500/>

46 Apa Billiards Patches Collection Pool 8 Ball & 9 Ball | Color: Black ...

<https://www.pinterest.com/pin/4596134647741449216/>

48 49 Patches

<https://tampabay.apaleagues.com/patches.aspx>

52 APA Member Patches - APA Of South Charlotte

<https://southcharlotte.apaleagues.com/CustomPage.aspx?q=4101>